Bukhari Chancery Persian Textbook Development

future-ani

PDF version of this file: future-ani.pdf

Grammatical Explanation

Central Asian Turki and Persian share an intentional future tense, also known as 'uncertain present-future tense' or the 'future participle', that expresses intentionality and probability. It is constructed simply by adding ī (ی) to the end of the infinitive verb: کردنی / карданӣ. In terms of orthography, Central Asian scribes often (but not always) wrote this form with the past stem and -nī separated: کرده نی. The meaning is not quite "they *will* do something": it is closer to "they *intend* to do something" or "they *might* do something."

Central Asian Persian also retains the present-future tense using the می / ме particle, which structurally indistinguishable from habitual action: می‌کند / мекунад can mean 'he is doing,' 'he will do,' or 'he (habitually) does'. However, this form (می‌کند) most often indicates *habitual* action or *future-promissory* (e.g., آگاهی داده میشود, 'let it be known that') when used in Central Asian Persian.

Modern Iranian Persian and classical Persian also have a dedicated future tense that implies greater certainy, which is uncommon in Central Asian Persian, though used in modern, high-register Tajik and is included in Tajik language textbooks: خواهد کرد / хоҳад кард. This form is found in classical

Persian as well, although less commonly than in modern usage: قدمی نِه به وداعش که روان خواهد شد 'Take a step [toward] bidding him farewell, for he will [soon] depart [i.e., die]' (Hafez).

Turkic languages have multiple ways of expressing future actions that imply either intentionality or indeterminancy. Two in particular, -ar and -maqchi, overlap with meanings of the -anī ending in Central Asian Persian.

The uncertain present-future tense is expressed with an -ar ending attached to the verb stem in Turki. In Uzbek and Chaghatay, the ending is invariable: -ar and ار, respectively. In Uyghur, it can be either ر or ار depending on whether the preceding consonant is voiced or unvoiced.

There is also significant overlap between the Central Asian Persian -anī suffix and the -moqchi / ماقچی - مەکچی verbal mood in modern Uzbek and Uyghur, which designates the intention to do something in the future. This Turkic verb form, however, is less common in pre-Soviet Turki texts, which makes the correspondence between -ar (Turki) and -anī (Central Asian Persian) perhaps closer. However, -moqchi is structurally the most similar to the -anī ending in Persian because both the -chi ending (in Uyghur / Uzbek) and the -ī ending (in Persian) can participalize the infinitive verb for an animate agent.

Thus, the -anī ending helps the reader narrow down the intended meaning in Central Asian Persian: او به آنجا رفتنی است means that the action of 'going' is likely or intended to take place in the future, but that the outcome is not certain to take place (unlike خواهد رفت in modern Iranian Persian). More broadly, this is the form readers of historical Central Asian Persian documents are most likely to encounter for expressing future tense.

Examples

> bukh: آدمهای ما بطرف ولایت هند و روم **رفتنی اند**

uzb: Bizning odamlarimiz Hindiston va Rum viloyatlari tomon **bormoqchilar**

fars: آدم‌های ما **قصد دارند** به سمت ولایت هند و روم **بروند**

eng: Our (i.e., those serving a Bukharan official) men **intend to go** to India and Rum (i.e., the Ottoman realm).

Comments:

This is the basic intentional-future pattern: the past stem raft- plus the -nī ending (رفتنی), followed by the plural copula اند. The departure is planned or likely, not certain.

Crucially, the subject (آدمهای ما) is animate and is the **agent** of the verb — the ones who intend to do the going — as opposed to modern Persian, where the identical-looking -ī ending forms a liyāqat ('worthiness') adjective describing an inanimate patient (این پیشنهاد پذیرفتنی است, 'this proposal is acceptable'). Spoken Tajik does not typical use the -ī adjectival ending in this manner, but can express a similar idea as follows: īn chāy mē-khurdagī būdast ('this tea is worth drinking') — not to be confused with the participal form, which modifies an animate subject (see Chapter []).

> Here the ending is written joined to the stem (رفتنی); as later examples show, Bukharan scribes sometimes separated it (رفته نی).

> Rūm (روم) here designates the Ottoman domains / Anatolia, not the city of Rome.

> bukh: که تا هر جائی که اهل اسلام است بنده **جواب کردنی است** و دیگر اینکه بنده با روس احکام دین و مذهب خود را جاری میکند

> uzb: Shuningdek, men yana ruslarga **javob bermoqchimanki** , qayerda islom ahli (musulmonlar) bo'lsa men o'sha yerda Islom ahkomlarini va o'z mazhabimni tatbiq qilmoqchiman. ...

> fars: که هرجایی که اهل اسلام هستند **جواب بدهم** به روس ها **مایلم** دیگر این که اینجانب احکام دین و مذهب خود را جاری می کنم

> eng: Also, this humble servant **intends to seek permission** from the Russians to spread the principles of religion to all lands where Muslims reside.

Comments:

> The basic meaning of jawāb is 'answer', but in this context it is an 'answer' to his request for permission, and is used elsewhere in the same file in conjunction with rukhṣat, lit. 'permission' (e.g., fol. 27a جواب و رخصت بیریب. This is similar in meaning to "give leave" (jawāb dādan in modern Persian).

> banda literally means 'servant' or 'slave', but here (and in the Islamic document tradition generally) refers to the first person, who is necessarily a slave of the sovereign, who is in turn a slave of God.

> maẕhab can refer to any of the four schools of Islamic law, but in this context would have implied the Hanafi school, which dominated Central Asia.

> bukh: هستند **گرفتنی** یک باب حویلی مانده گی می باشد که مذکور را حکومت بخارا نیز

> uzb: bir uy qolgan bo'lib, uni ham Bukhoro hukumati **olmoqchi** dirlar.

fars: آن است **مایل به گرفتن** یک باب خانه باقی مانده است که دولت بخارا

eng: There is one dwelling remaining which the [officials of the] government of Bukhara also **intend** to confiscate.

Comments:

Note that the subject (حکومتِ بخارا) is grammatically singular, but the plural verb implies that multiple government officials are carrying out the action.

In this example, olmoqchi better approximates the intended meaning of the Persian than olar because it emphasizes the intentionality of the action, rather than the indeterminancy. However, olar is also a possible translations, and the -moqchi ending would have been less likely in nineteenth-century Turki.

The participle مانده گی might more literally be translated into modern Persian with a relative particle (خانه که مانده است), and closely approximates the Turki-Uzbek participle qolgan: see the chapter on participles.

This example was drawn from a bilingual document (common for correspondence between Bukharan and Russian colonial respective authorities), which means that

> we know exactly how the colonial translator understood this construction: Бухарское Правительство также хочет конфисковать, "the Bukharan government also wishes to confiscate..."

> The 'hovli' is a type of Central Asian house with an open courtyard, and the term is still used. Though it might be understood in Iran as well, it is here translated to the more generic Persian term for 'house' (خانه).

bukh: خواجه **دعوی کردنی بوده است** ضعیفه خود بخواجه بیک چیز های مانده گی خود را بیک گریخته رفته بوده است

uzb: Ayol Xoja Bekdan o'zining qolgan mol-mulki uchun **da'vo qilmoqchi bo'lgan ekan** , [ammo] Xoja Bek qochib ketgan ekan.

fars: زن **قصد داشت** علیه خواجه بیک بابت اموال باقی‌ماندهٔ خود **اقامهٔ دعوی کند** ، اما خواجه بیک گریخته بود.

eng: The woman **had intended to bring a claim** against Khwaja Bek for her remaining property, but Khwaja Bek had fled.

Comments:

> This example shows that the uncertain future is **relative** to the other actions in the sentence. The compound copula بوده است places the intended action (daʿwā kardanī, 'to bring a claim') in the past relative to the narration: it was future only from the woman's standpoint, not from the writer's. The intention was never realized, because it was preempted by another past event — Khwaja Bek's flight.

> Note the contrast between the two past forms: کردنی بوده است marks an intended-but-unrealized action, whereas گریخته رفته بوده است ('had fled') reports an action that actually took place.

> The term ضعیفه literally means 'weak (one)' in Arabic (feminine of żaʿīf), but it is a common, unmarked term for 'woman' in Central Asian Persian, roughly equivalent to زن.

> The verb daʿwā kardan is legal register here — 'to bring a suit / lodge a claim', not merely 'to claim'. On مانده گی as a participle ('remaining'), see the chapter on participles.

bukh: در روز شنبه ۲۷ ماه رجب پنج نفر گنه گان مذکور شده را جوره بیک میرزا باشی شدند **بُرده نی** مع یک ضعیفه گنه کار گردانیده آورده در بخارای شریف

uzb: 27-rajab oyining dushanba kuni Jo'rabek Mirzoboshi mazkur besh nafar gunohkorlarni bir ayol bilan gunahkor qilib Buxoroi sharifga **olib bormoqchi** bo'ldilar

fars: در روز شنبه ۲۷ ماه رجب جوره بیک میرزا باشی پنج گناه کرده نامبرده را همراه با **برده شوند** به بخارای شریف **قرار شد که** یک زن، گنه کار شمرد و آورد و

eng: On Saturday, the 27th of the month of Rajab (Islamic calendar), Jura Bek Mirza Bashi escorted five aforementioned criminals, along with one woman, whom he had (also) accused of criminal activities, and it was decided that they were **all to be brought** to Bukhara.

Comments:

> Unlike the earlier examples, the -anī form here is **passive**: it attaches to شدن (burdanī shudand, 'were to be brought') rather than to a copula. As a result, the five prisoners are the ones being acted upon — the ones brought — rather than the ones doing the intending. This is why, unlike in the earlier examples, no one in the sentence is a willing agent,

even though the grammatical subject (the prisoners) is still animate.

In Bukharan chancery orthography, the نی ending is often separated from the verb (here بردەنی instead of بردنی). This convention makes it easy to mistake this future tense for a negated sentence (e.g., burda na-shudand, 'were not taken'). This orthography may be evidence of the vernacular character of this construction, i.e., the scribes transcribed the pronunciation of the verb form, rather than reproducing a participle derived from the infinitive reproduced from the literary tradition. Note also that this orthographic difference essentially "washes out" in Tajik Cyrillic transliteration, i.e., both alternatives would become бурданӣ, whether or not the word was written with a break in the middle.

Jura Bek Mirza is the grammatical subject of the first part of the sentence, but not of the passive final verb (burdanī shudand). We approximated the meaning with "it was decided that" / قرار شد که, even though the original does not necessarily state that a decision was made.

Note that this scribe freely uses even Arabic conjunctions (مع, 'with'), a common practice in this kind of text. On ضعیفه ('woman'), see above.

bukh: از سیف الملوک مذکور قرضدار شده **دادنی شد**

uzb: Mazkur Sayfulmulukdan qarzdor bo'lgan (narsasi)ni **bermoqchi bo'ldi**

fars: چون به سیف‌الملوکِ مذکور بدهکار شده بود، **مقرر شد که بپردازد**

eng: Having become indebted to the aforementioned Sayf al-Muluk, [he] **was obligated to pay**.

Comments:

This example shows a different **valence**. In the boxes above the -anī form expressed the subject's own intention; here دادنی شد (dādanī shud) expresses an externally imposed **obligation** — 'was to pay', 'became liable to pay' — not a wish or plan. Combined with شد, the construction marks that the payment was settled or required. This is close to the English gerundive 'the sum to be paid'.

The same document uses the form the same way a few lines earlier: مهلت گرفته تردد می‌نمایم گفته دادنی شد, roughly 'having asked for a delay, saying "I will deliberate," it was settled that he would pay.' This obligatory reading is common in

> fiscal and legal contexts. (Same dispute file as the دعوی کردنی box above.)

Historical-Grammatical Exploration

There is some undertainty about whether — from a morphological perspective — this tense is formed from the stem or the infinitive (a distinction that does not matter from the standpoint of reading comprehension). As mentioned in some of the examples above, orthographic clues seem to suggest that Bukharan scribes understood this construction as an -nī suffix added to the past stem, which is suggested by (inconsistently) separating the two components with a space: کرده‌نی.

Although this chapter treats the -anī form primarily as an intentional future, the construction also carries a deontic (obligatory) sense in fiscal and legal documents, where it marks what is required or settled rather than merely intended: دادنی شد, 'was to be paid / became liable to pay' (see example 6 above). A comparable extension appears in narrative prose. The chronicle تاریخ نافعی of Baljuwan uses it in a conditional, prescriptive register: اگر به یک شهر و ولایت حاکم کردنی از عمل توقسابه گی لایق به حاکمی گری است، یرلیق داده می‌فرستانند, 'if someone to be appointed governor of a city or province is [drawn] from the rank of tūqsāba and is worthy of governorship, they issue a decree and send [him].' Here حاکم کردنی shades from intention toward worthiness/eligibility, which brings the Central Asian form closer to the Iranian liyāqat sense discussed below. Taken together, these uses suggest the construction is better understood as a broad prospective/deontic participle whose default reading is intentional.

- *JP: Decide whether the chapter framing should be widened from "intentional future" to "prospective/deontic participle"; verify the Baljuwani citation (baljuwani_tarikh-i_nafi, ser. 1032).*

Morphologically, the -anī form can also combine with the istādan progressive auxiliary to express ongoing or imminent intent: وثیقه بر آورده از تصرف من گرفتنی شده استاده اند, 'they have produced a document and are [now, imminently] intending to seize it from my possession' (O'zMA i126-1-155, ser. 1536, l. 66). This layering of گرفتنی + شده + استاده اند is uncommon, but it shows that the construction behaves like a regular participle that can be embedded under further auxiliaries.

In modern Persian, "adjectives of merit / worthiness," also known as "liyāqat adjectives," are a type of verbal adjective formed by adding the suffix -ī / ی to the infinitive stem. For instance: خوردنی، دیدنی، گسستنی. As in Central Asian Persian, these adjectives belong to the future tense category in terms of their aspectual modality. However, in practice this form tends to imply desirability or worthiness of action (hence liyāqat, lit. 'worthiness') in the future, rather than intent or possibility: این فیلم دیدنی است, 'this film is worth seeing'. For this reason, the subject of -ani constructions tend to be animate in Central Asian Persian, but inanimate in Iranian Persian.

- *LS: Do we want to include some examples from classical Persian and /or further discussion?*

Classical Persian illustrates both poles of this form. In Firdawsī it appears nominalized, as a noun for the thing acted upon: فرستاد هرگونه‌ای خوردنی ز پوشیدنی هم ز گستردنی, 'he sent every kind of thing to eat, and of clothing and bedding' — where خوردنی, پوشیدنی, and گستردنی denote edibles, garments, and bedding. The worthiness/possibility sense is clear in Bīdil Dihlawī: از نقش ما حقیقت آفاق خواندنی است, 'from our image the reality of the horizons is legible [worth reading]'. In both, the subject is the inanimate thing undergoing the action, in contrast to the animate, intending subject of the Central Asian construction.

Although it is not a dirrect antecedent, Middle Persian (Pahlavi) had a verb form with similar logic to the intentional future in Central Asian Persian: the verbal adjective formed by the -išnīg ending usually refers to the future and implies intentionality.

References

- Central Asian Persian / Tajik: Perry, 264-267 discusses this construction as the "future participle" meaning "about to do something" with the "connotation of volition or intention."
- Uyghur: De Jong (128-130) discusses ھر / ار as the "uncertain present-future tense," which expresses an action in the future with "vague intention, or probability."
- Farsi: The classic studies of the liyāqat construction are Ṣādiqī, ʿAlī Ashraf (1993/1372) “Shīvihā va imkānāt-i vāzhisāzi dar zabān-i fārsī-yi muʿāṣir”, Nashr-i dānish, sāl-i 13, shumāri-yi 3 pp, 9-15 va shumāri-yi 4, pp 15-23.